



MAHESH TICKLEY

CHANGING EQUATIONS Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Mahayuti leaders in Nagpur, Apr. 10; (left) a file photo of Bihar CM Nitish Kumar with his then deputy Tejashwi Yadav, Sept. 2023

IN MAHARASHTRA, THE SYMPATHY VOTE MAY GO TO PAWAR SR AND UDDHAV. THE SHINDE SENA AND AJIT'S NCP MAY LET THE BJP DOWN

too, on her part, is building on their insecurity in many of her rallies, telling them how a BJP government will throw them out of India by moving on the National Register for Citizens (NRC) next.

While Modi and the BJP are taking on Mamata on corruption and the sexual abuse allegations in Sandeshkhali, the chief minister is playing the "victim card" and saying her state is being denied money the central government owes it for schemes such as the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA). This, even as she showcases the slew of welfare schemes her government has launched. Though Mamata refused to enter into a seat-sharing arrangement with fellow INDIA (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance) constituents—the Left parties and the Congress—many experts believe it could work in her favour. Political analyst Jayanto Ghosal, for instance, believes that the Left parties are unlikely to ask their cadre to vote for the BJP as they did the last time to thwart Mamata, as they have realised that ended in them being marginalised by the BJP. They may, therefore, prefer to remain neutral or back Mamata this time, to the BJP's detriment in either case. Ghosal also points out how BJP's Hindutva push has no purchase among the Bengali Hindus, who have faith in the multiple deities of their own.

In Bihar, political strategist Amitabh Tiwari, in keeping with the ongoing IPL season, uses a cricketing analogy to sum up the situation. He believes the two major opposing sides have strong captains—Modi at the helm of the NDA in the state and Tejashwi doing the honours on the INDIA side. But both the vice-captains, Nitish Kumar in the NDA and the Congress in INDIA, are the weak links. So, while the NDA executed a near-clean sweep in 2019 by winning 39 of the 40 seats, this time, the Tejashwi-led RJD may gain at the JD(U)'s expense. Deshmukh agrees that Nitish's frequent flip-flops have made him a liability for the NDA. "I haven't seen anybody's rating fall so drastically as Nitish's. But we still don't know whether the Bihari will vote with a Lok Sabha mindset or an assembly one," he says. In Bihar, too, as in the other two states, Modi remains a strong pull factor for the BJP, and is likely to help the party retain its tally, even though Tejashwi has worked hard to expand the Muslim-Yadav combination and wooed the Extremely Backward Class (EBC) community that traditionally backed Nitish. As in Maharashtra, in Bihar, the BJP may be weighed down by Nitish and its other allies in the NDA.

Plus, the Opposition is not giving up without a fight. The increased penetration of mobile telephony and the internet is helping them spread their message better via social media platforms, somewhat neutralising the saffron party's advantage of having more campaign resources. But the complex interplay of parties and factors still makes poll prediction a tough task this election season. Compounding it is the fact that the elections in these three states will be long drawn out. While Maharashtra votes in five phases, going up to May 20, both West Bengal and Bihar will be voting right up to the seventh and final phase on June 1. What is clear is that it will be a fight to the finish and only on June 4 will we know whether the might of the BJP and its allies prevails or the valiant fight of the doughty regional satraps not only helps them hold their ground but causes a major upset as well. ■